

# Spanish Renaissance

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**D**uring the 15th and 16th centuries, Italian Renaissance ideas spread to Spain, where great changes were occurring. From 1479 to 1504, Isabella of Castile and Ferdinand of Aragon jointly ruled the country and aimed to unify it under Roman Catholicism. They expelled Jews and Muslims (Moors) and set up a religious Inquisition to police heresy, but also sponsored Columbus's four voyages to the Americas.

Spanish Renaissance artists included Fernando Gallego (c.1440–1507) who painted in a dramatic, yet naturalistic manner, clearly influenced by Flemish painting. The Cretan-born painter, sculptor and architect El Greco (1541–1614) trained in icon painting and studied under Titian and moved to Spain in his mid-30s. His elongated, unnaturally coloured pictures blended ideas from Byzantine art, the Venetian Renaissance and Mannerism, illustrating the strict piety of the Counter-Reformation. With his precise style and warm colouring, Alonso Sánchez Coello (1531–88) was a pioneer of Spanish portrait painting.



El Greco, *The Vision of Saint John*, 1608–14